longer saw India as nonaligned.[10] India's diversified set of relationships had given it not just more independence, but more status and influence—being just another of Moscow's partners did not give India the same role or importance.

India tried other ways of dealing with overdependence on Moscow. It broadened its relations with a number of middle powers.[11] This, for example, allowed it to diversify its sources of military supply so that India's import dependence on the Soviet Union fell from 70 percent in the early 1970s to 50 percent by 1977. India also continued to develop its nuclear program, conducting a peaceful nuclear explosion in 1974. Furthermore, it worked toward developing indigenous capability across the board. As an Indian diplomat had noted as he had watched the Sino-US and US-Soviet détentes, "The lesson to be learnt is that we must really be self-reliant."[12] Finally, during this period, India would also seek rapprochements with China and Pakistan, which could help limit its need for Moscow.

Repairing Relations

At the end of 1972, L. K. Jha had emphasized, "The question we have to ask ourselves is, first whether there is any need, and second if there is any desire in either country to improve these relations."[13] As far as India was concerned, the answer was yes—the US option was still necessary. By 1973 the sheen had worn off the Gandhi government. The domestic economic and security pictures were not looking good, and the oil crisis and a bad monsoon made the situation worse. By 1974, the American embassy in Delhi would report, "This country is in trouble."[14] India still needed American assistance and approval, and it needed the US to help it balance its dependence on the Soviet Union. So Delhi worked to correct the imbalance.

Foreign ministry officials did not think that the US would go "out of its way" to improve relations with India, but they did believe that the Nixon administration's pragmatism gave them an opportunity. After all there were some dynamics that might lead Washington to seek an improvement of relations as well:

> Bad relations with India are not really necessary for its rapprochement with China or for any other of its foreign policy